ZP-A Illustrated Companion

How state accumulates without ever going backwards

Lattice Algebra

ZP Companion | Initial: April 2026 | Current: 1.15, November 2026

This companion explains the ideas in plain language with diagrams and real-world examples. It is not the formal document — every claim here restates a result already proved in the corresponding technical document. Consult that document for the authoritative mathematics.

What Is ZP-A Doing?

ZP-A establishes the algebraic rules for how states behave in this framework. It uses a structure called a join-semilattice — the simplest algebraic system that can describe accumulation without subtraction. Think of it as a ledger where entries can only be added, never erased.

The central object is the triple $(L, \vee, \bot)$: a set of states L, a joining operation $\vee$ that combines two states into a larger one, and a special bottom element $\bot$ that represents the absolute starting point. Four axioms (A1–A4) say that joining is associative, commutative, idempotent, and that $\bot$ is a neutral element.

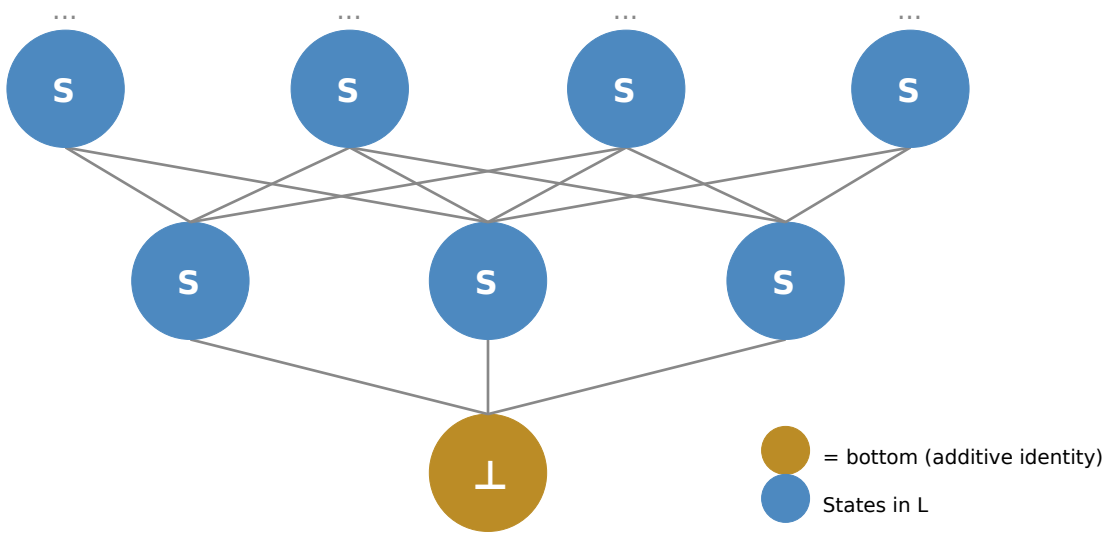
Real-world example — Bank ledger

Think of $\bot$ as a brand-new account with zero balance. Every transaction adds to the ledger. There is no undo operation — once a deposit is recorded, the total can only stay the same or grow. The join-semilattice captures exactly this: accumulation without reversal.

Remember: The bank account is just one way to picture it. The framework applies to any system where state can only accumulate — energy, information, or any other monotone quantity.

The Partial Order: States Have a Natural Height

From the four axioms, a partial order falls out automatically: state x is "below" y if joining x with y just gives y back — y already contains everything x does. $\bot$ is always at the very bottom.



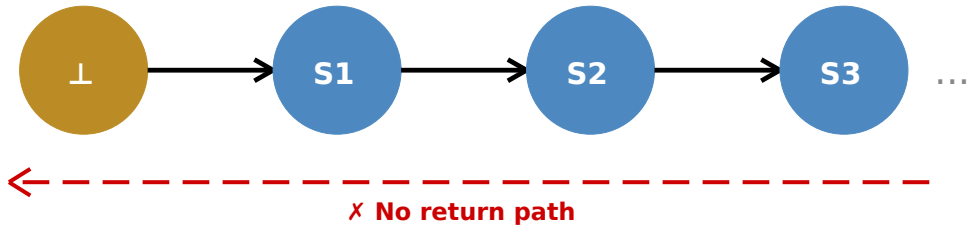
Hasse diagram: partial order on L. Arrows point upward. ⊥ (amber) is the universal minimum. Every state sits above ⊥.

Real-world example — Biological complexity

Think of ⊥ as the simplest possible organism. More complex life forms are "above" simpler ones: they contain everything the simpler form has, plus more. In this abstract sense, complexity only accumulates.

No Subtraction

The join-semilattice deliberately omits subtraction. State content can only accumulate, never be removed. Every valid transition moves upward.



State transitions are one-directional. The red dashed line — a return path — does not exist in this algebra.

Key Result: Monotonicity is a Theorem — not an Assumption (T3)

For any state sequence built by joining, $S_0 \leq S_1 \leq S_2 \leq \ldots$ This is derived from the axioms, not assumed. The sequence can only go up.

Key Result: ⊥ is a Constituent of Every State (T2)

$\bot \leq x$ for all x in L. $\bot$ is not a void that states escape from — it is algebraically present in every state. Zero is not absence; it is the universal base.

Real-world example — Silence in music

Silence is not the absence of the piece — it is the baseline from which every note departs. Every musical state contains silence as its foundation. The join-semilattice captures this: $\bot$ is a constituent of every state.

More Examples of Join-Semilattices

A join-semilattice appears in many mathematical and everyday settings. Here are four concrete instantiations of $(L, \vee, \bot)$, each satisfying A1–A4.

Example — Power set with union

Let X be any set. Take $L = P(X)$ (the collection of all subsets of X), $\vee = \cup$ (set union), and $\bot = \varnothing$ (the empty set). Union is associative, commutative, idempotent ($A \cup A = A$), and the empty set is a neutral element ($\varnothing \cup A = A$). The induced order is inclusion: $A \leq B$ iff $A \cup B = B$, i.e. $A \subseteq B$. Every element of L sits above $\varnothing$.

Example — [0, ∞) with maximum

Take $L = [0, \infty)$, $\vee = \max$ (the larger of two values), and $\bot = 0$. Maximum is associative, commutative, idempotent ($\max(x, x) = x$), and 0 is a neutral element ($\max(0, x) = x$ for $x \geq 0$). The induced order is the usual $\leq$ on real numbers: $x \leq y$ iff $\max(x, y) = y$. Note: addition would not work here — $x + x = 2x \neq x$, violating idempotency (A3).

Example — Functions with pointwise maximum

Let X be any set. Take L to be the set of all functions $f: X \to [0, \infty)$, $\vee$ = pointwise maximum ($(f \vee g)(x) = \max(f(x), g(x))$), and $\bot$ = the zero function. All four axioms hold pointwise. The induced order is $f \leq g$ iff $f(x) \leq g(x)$ for all $x \in X$. This is a function-space version of the previous example — one level up in abstraction.

Note: $[0, \infty)$ with maximum is a valid join-semilattice, and $\mathbb{R}$ works perfectly well as an algebraic structure here. But as a metric substrate for the Binary Snap, $\mathbb{R}$ fails — for any positive ε, the element $\varepsilon/2$ is always smaller, so no minimal first step can exist. This is the subject of ZP-F (The Counterexamples), which proves that no linearly ordered field has a least positive element (f_snap_impossible); what obstructs a first step is density (axb1_fails_everywhere_iff_dense). Among the completions of $\mathbb{Q}$, $\mathbb{Q}_2$'s topology removes that obstruction (padic_snaps) but supplies no first step: Mathlib gives $\mathbb{Q}_2$ no order, and under the norm preorder 0 has no first step there either (ZeroParadox/BottomCannotBe.lean). The first step is supplied by AX-B1, a commitment (ZeroParadox/Order/SnapCannotBe.lean, § V).

Example — Document edit history

Open a document and start making edits. Even hitting Backspace does not erase from the edit record — it adds a new deletion event to the history. Each saved state of the document sits above all states that preceded it. The history can only grow. The "join" of two document states is the later one (or the merge if branches exist). The $\bot$ state is the empty document. No edit operation removes from the record.

⊥ Contains Itself (CC-2)

Every state sits above ⊥. But what exactly is ⊥? The standard answer: the additive identity, the algebraic zero, the starting point. ZP-A adds a sharper answer in terms of a role, the Quine atom (CC-2): a point that steps to itself and to nothing else. Which point fills it depends on the step, as the next paragraph details: under a self-application map whose only fixed point is ⊥, ⊥ fills it; under membership, the host's own bottom fills it, and that is ⊥ of the lattice exactly when the host is built with ⊥ as its bottom, as the host built from the lattice's AFA structure is (the examples after quineAtomHost_quine_role_iff, ZeroParadox/Settheory/QuineDichotomy.lean). In set theory, where a set steps to its members, that role is filled by a set that equals its own singleton.

Formally, the role is stated in each setting on its own terms rather than as one equation. In a lattice given a self-application map whose only fixed point is ⊥ (even the constant map to ⊥ qualifies), with that map as the step, ⊥ is the only point filling it. With membership as the step, in a host whose bottom is its own only member and where no other element is its own only member, that host's bottom is the only point filling it. No ordinary, well-founded set fills it at all. No equation between ⊥ and a set is stated, since the two live in different types. Where the role is filled here it is filled once, so there is no multiplicity.

Why this matters

Can there be two "copies" of ⊥ that are somehow different? A Quine atom says no. Any object identical to ⊥ in all structural respects IS ⊥. There is nothing external to ⊥ by which to distinguish copies.

A label requires a labeller outside it. A point that steps only to itself has no outside. That rules out an outside executor; it does not by itself make ⊥ run. That the snap at P_0 is an execution rather than a description being read is what the occurrence commitment asserts (ZP-E), and DA-1 consumes it.

Technical note (CC-2): for a set to fill the Quine-atom role, the host set theory must drop the classical Axiom of Foundation (which rules out self-containing sets, so under it no set fills the role); the framework replaces it with Aczel's Anti-Foundation Axiom (AFA), one of several anti-foundation axioms that admit such a set. The Axiom of Choice is not assumed. This is a framework-level commitment about the host theory — A1–A4 are unaffected, and no equation makes ⊥ of the lattice a set. For a plain-language explanation of why Foundation is incompatible with a set that is its own only member, see the ZP-J Illustrated Companion; for why AFA is adopted rather than forced, see ZP-E Remark R-AFA.

Remember: ZP-A makes no claims about topology, probability, or physics. It only establishes the algebraic skeleton. Everything it claims can be verified by a reader fluent in algebra without consulting any other document.